

Humans have a great desire for power. Not just plain power but complete and absolute power. This desire for power becomes a person's drive to wake up everyday and do something productive that contributes to their attainment of this goal. Similarly, on a larger context, distinct societies aspire for greatness. Greatness in terms of economic influence, culture, and education. Together, these desire for greatness and power are achieved through systems design they implemented to the world namely colonialism, imperialism, and capitalism. The same systems that cause and nurture suffering, inequality, and conflict since its inception.

Colonialism is the practice of controlling an area or people by subjugating it to one people of power. In this system, a foreign (country of) power establishes colonies in the territory it tries to manipulate for its benefit. The benefits include exploitation of natural resources and labor. The colony becomes its weapon to make the lives of the inhabitants difficult, marginalized, and in constant, disarray. A perfect example of colonialism was the subjugation of the Philippines to Spain. The more than 300 years of being in exploitative systems, like encomiendas and theocracy, have resulted to Filipinos suffering. The Spaniards were the ones who control the resources that Filipinos have produced. Filipinos become slaves that work for their "superiors". The Filipinos are seen as unequal to the Spaniards. The inhabitants' identities are reduced to a lower class in the caste system which are only entitled to little privileges. Thus, it can only be saved through religious conversions or imitation of the Spaniards. Consequently, this desire for Filipinos to be like Spaniards have caused internal conflict – development of inferior identity - and external conflict – division among Filipinos.

When the Philippines was sold to the Americans, cultural hegemony occurred. Filipinos want the American dream. The dream of living a life of grandiose and fame. While Filipinos relish this illusion, the Americans have set their eyes on establishing economic influence on the country. This is manifested by our government system and the approval of the Bell Trade Act of 1946 which exemplifies an unequal control of trade between the Philippines and the United States where most strategic economic decisions are decided by the Americans. This is how imperialism works. In this system, foreign power changes the course of the direction of the economy and culture for its benefit. Economic decisions and culture supremacy are dealt in favor of the powerful.

Another system related to imperialism and colonialism is capitalism. In capitalism, social services, goods, and resources are controlled by private organizations. Resources and labor are exploited for profit of the organization. They contribute to suffering, inequality, and conflict because it breaks the culture of cooperation, unity, and equality. Laborers suffer from inhumane wages. They receive unequal and poor treatment from employers. Hence, the multiple identities they possess even bar them from getting employment like race, ethnicity, SOGIE, and ability. This in turn, create competition among laborers for the prize of social mobility.

With all these three, we can say that suffering, inequality, and conflict are completely intertwined phenomena. They exist for one another. However, digging deeper into the motivations behind this system, greatness and power are associated with development. Development in terms economy, culture, education, and society. According to Wolfgang (2009), when the United States became a foreign power during the post-World War 2, its immediate agenda was to make its supremacy felt by the world. It embarked to a new era where its prosperity was used to allure other poor countries to walk “side-by-side” with them on its way to greatness. Successful in its campaign, underdeveloped countries immediately fell into the trap for what he called American hegemony. Countries were softly colonized through the presence of naval bases and influenced through dependence on the American economy, higher value for surplus goods, and the domination of American culture. And all these have caused suffering, created inequalities, and established conflict among nations.

Going back to my first point, humans desire for power and greatness have led us to a world of suffering, inequality, and conflict. However, it does not end there. In order for us to stop these from persisting, we need change our ways, rediscover ourselves, and maximize our strengths. Moreover, Wolfgang (2009) mentioned that redefining what development/underdevelopment really means should be the responsibility of the oppressed and subjugated, not the oppressor and subjugator. The development of a country is determined by its people because they possess the ability to self-determine the culture, economy, education, and system that enrich them (Philpott, 1995).

References

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